Chuan Zhu

Ph.D. Candidate, School of Management, Fudan University
Shanghai, China
Email | Website | Google Scholar | ORCID | LinkedIn

EDUCATION

Fudan University, School of Management — expected 2027
Ph.D. in Business Artificial Intelligence — *Shanghai, China*

- Research focus: Human–AI work allocation and decision authority in service operations.
- Advisor: Tianjun Feng.

Northeast Forestry University — 2018
B.S. in Logistics Engineering

INDUSTRY COLLABORATION AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Alibaba Group, Customer Operations Department — July 2022 – Present
Research Scientist; Academic Research Collaboration — *Hangzhou, China*

- Conduct embedded research on human–AI service system design, workforce management, and AI-enabled customer operations.
- Collaborate with operational teams to design and evaluate field interventions using large-scale operational data, field experimentation, and causal inference.
- Translate operational challenges into research questions and feasible empirical designs.

Environmental Defense Fund & LONGi Green Energy — July 2021 – Oct. 2021
Climate Corps Fellow — *Xi'an, China*

- Analyzed supplier carbon-management challenges and benchmarked green supply-chain practices.
- Developed a supplier empowerment roadmap covering training, renewable-energy adoption, monitoring, and incentives. [Project]

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Research: Human–AI work design and decision authority; AI-enabled service systems and digital platforms; service operations; human–AI collaboration.

Methods: Field experiments; causal inference; machine learning; LLM-based text analysis.

WORKING PAPERS

[1] Yiwei Wang*, **Chuan Zhu***, Tianjun Feng, Lauren Xiaoyuan Lu, Bingxin Jia. "Agentic AI and Human-in-the-Loop Interventions: Field Experimental Evidence from Alibaba's Customer Service Operations." (**Equal contribution*; ***Job Market Paper.***)

- **Major Revision, *Operations Research*.** [SSRN | arXiv]
- **Finalist, 2026 INFORMS Service Science Best Student Paper Competition.**
- **Best Paper Nominee, CIST 2026.**
- Uses a randomized field experiment involving 647 workers and approximately 681,000 customer-service chats at Alibaba Taobao.
- Finds that agentic AI reduces average chat duration but may lower customer ratings; descriptive post-escalation analyses show more favorable outcomes after technical than emotional escalations, with differences in intervention timing and human effort.

[2] **Chuan Zhu**, Tom Fangyun Tan, Tianjun Feng. "Talk the Talk and Walk the Walk: An Empirical Study of Front-Office Communication and Back-Office Problem Solving Under Workload Pressure." Working paper.

- Uses detailed clickstream and transcript data from 3,965,028 live-chat sessions handled by 7,004 agents to examine how workload changes effort allocation between front-office customer-facing communication and background problem solving.
- Combines instrumental-variable control-function estimation with nonlinear mediation analysis and LDA- and LLM-based textual measures.
- Finds a U-shaped relationship between workload and communication effort; counterfactual estimates suggest that rebalancing effort can shorten sessions, improve customer ratings, and reduce retrials without additional capacity.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

"Agentic AI and Human-in-the-Loop Interventions: Field Experimental Evidence from Alibaba's Customer Service Operations."

- INFORMS Annual Meeting, 2026 — Service Science Best Student Paper Competition Finalist Session; Nov. 2, 2:45–4:00 PM, Moscone South 20, Hall E.
- POMS Annual Meeting, 2026 — Accepted for presentation.
- CIST, 2026 — Accepted for presentation.
- WISE, 2026 — Accepted for presentation.

"Talk the Talk and Walk the Walk: An Empirical Study of Front-Office Communication and Back-Office Problem Solving Under Workload Pressure."

- POMS-HK, 2026.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant

- Operations Management, MBA, Spring 2022.
- Data-Driven Market Analysis, Master's, Fall 2021.
- Microeconomics, Undergraduate, Spring 2019.
- Theories and Practices of Entrepreneurship, Undergraduate, Spring 2019.

Teaching Interests: Operations Management; Service Operations; Business Analytics; AI in Business.

HONORS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND AWARDS

Best Paper Nominee, CIST 2026 2026

Finalist, INFORMS Service Science Best Student Paper Competition 2026

Climate Corps Fellow, Environmental Defense Fund 2021

Outstanding Academic Scholarship, School of Management, Fudan University 2019

PROGRAMMING AND RESEARCH SKILLS

AI / ML: Machine learning; LLM-based text analysis and evaluation; NLP; RAG; model adaptation.

Programming: Python; R; Stata; SQL.

Optimization / Tools: MATLAB; Gurobi; LaTeX.

REFERENCES

Tianjun Feng
Professor
School of Management, Fudan University
Shanghai, China
Email | Website

Yiwei Wang
Assistant Professor
International Business School, Zhejiang University
Hangzhou, China
Email | Website

Lauren Xiaoyuan Lu
Norman W. Martin 1925 Professor of Business Administration
Tuck School of Business, Dartmouth College
Email | Website